

AGENTIC AI • EXECUTIVE CAPABILITY • MEASURABLE OUTCOMES

Leadership skills to Deliver ROI with Agents

A practical guide for leaders who want to build agentic AI capability, run focused pilots and turn AI investments into measurable business value.

START NOW

Learn agentic AI skills with pilots

Agentic AI will change how organisations operate. Leaders need the skills and knowledge to work alongside the technology, assess its limits and make accountable choices about where it creates value.

It is time for executives to lean in with a hands-on mentality and engage directly with the tools. Think big, even if you start small. Whatever you do, start.

> **Leadership posture:** You do not need to code. You do need to understand what agents can do, where they fail, what they change in the underlying process and what governance they require.

THE THREE HABITS TO BUILD NOW

Use the tools

Make time to test internal agents, challenge them and give informed feedback.

Demand evidence

Ask teams to show the process before and after the agent, not simply describe the opportunity.

Keep learning

Set an example of weekly education for your senior team and the wider organisation.

Own the impact

Be accountable for the technology, business process, employee experience and measurable outcome.

Test and play

Allocate dedicated time to experiment with internal agentic applications. Hands-on use turns abstract AI strategy into a realistic understanding of capability, limitation and risk.

1

Use the agent yourself

If your organisation is developing a new service agent for support, insist on using it. Experience the interaction, inputs, outputs and hand-offs as a user would.

2

Challenge it deliberately

Test difficult, ambiguous and edge-case scenarios. Ask whether the agent is accurate, useful, safe and clear about when a human needs to step in.

3

Give specific feedback

Turn observations into prioritised improvement requests: knowledge gaps, unsafe behaviour, unclear decision logic, poor user experience or missing process ownership.

LEADERSHIP QUESTIONS FOR EVERY PILOT

- What decision, task or customer/employee need is the agent supporting?
- What information can the agent use, and what information must it not use?
- Where does it perform reliably, and where are human review or escalation required?
- What will we measure: quality, speed, cost, satisfaction, risk or capacity?

> **Remember:** You do not need to code, but you must understand the agent’s capabilities and limitations well enough to lead responsibly.

02 • MAKE VALUE VISIBLE

Insist on demos and proofs of concept

When teams present investment plans, request live demonstrations of the agent's behaviour and the business process it transforms.

> "Show me the process before the agent and after the agent."

That simple request makes a discussion concrete. It helps leaders see the work, the decision points, the human role, the system dependencies and the outcome that should improve.

WHAT A GOOD DEMONSTRATION SHOWS

Current state

The real workflow today: inputs, manual tasks, delays, error points, rework and escalation.

Future state

How the agent changes the workflow, including human checkpoints and exception handling.

Agent behaviour

Live examples of the agent responding to typical, complex and unexpected scenarios.

Business impact

The measure that will improve, baseline performance and how results will be tracked.

EXECUTIVE ACCOUNTABILITY

Leaders should be accountable for the technology and the impact it can have. That means asking whether the proposed solution solves a meaningful problem, is governed appropriately and has a clear owner after the proof of concept ends.

Adopt the one-hour rule

Encourage yourself and your senior team to spend at least one dedicated hour each week building agentic AI fluency.

Read

Review industry research, governance guidance or a relevant article focused on agentic workflows.

Listen

Engage with a relevant podcast, practitioner discussion or leadership briefing.

Study

Review a case study that makes the workflow, the controls and the business outcome visible.

Discuss

Use leadership-team time to share what you learned and what it could mean for your organisation.

SET THE STANDARD FROM THE TOP

Leaders must set standards for ongoing education across the business. Everyone will need to keep learning, so this mentality should be visible from the C-suite down.

> **Weekly prompt:** What did we learn this week about agentic workflows, governance or value creation that should change a decision, a priority or a pilot?

SIMPLE TEAM RITUAL

At the end of each month, ask senior leaders to bring one practical example: a process to test, a useful case study, a governance lesson or a decision that needs better evidence.

PROVE THE VALUE

Show the ROI of AI with specific productivity gains

Be more robust about demonstrating the ROI of AI deployments. Focus on specific productivity gains rather than vague promises, tying agentic AI to individual, quantifiable process improvements.

ROI case = a defined process + a measurable baseline + an agent-enabled change + a verified outcome

BUILD THE EVIDENCE

- Define the unit of work: ticket, request, lead, case, document, decision or interaction.
- Capture the starting point: volume, cycle time, error/rework, quality, cost and employee/customer effort.
- Specify what the agent will do and where a person remains accountable.
- Measure the change over an agreed period and distinguish realised results from forecasts.
- Convert time saved into real capacity only when the organisation can redeploy, remove or repurpose that work.

> **Avoid:** generic claims such as “AI will transform productivity.” State the task, scale, baseline, outcome, owner and evidence instead.

PROVEN USE CASES

Three ways agents can create value

1. **Automation of repetitive tasks**
   Agents can autonomously handle routine, time-consuming tasks such as initial ticket triage, basic data entry and lead qualification. Calculate time saved per employee and the total full-time-equivalent capacity freed up.

2. **Augmentation of expertise**
   Agents can empower employees, for example by giving a sales representative real-time, context-aware next-best-action coaching. This focuses on quality improvement and speed of execution, leading to higher win rates or faster resolution times.

3. **Rapid innovation cycles**
   Agentic AI can quickly prototype solutions, analyse large datasets for opportunities or personalise offerings at scale. These are tasks that can be too slow or expensive for human teams alone.

MEASURES TO SELECT DELIBERATELY

Efficiency

Cycle time, handling time, throughput, backlog reduction and capacity released.

Quality

Accuracy, first-time resolution, compliance, error reduction and decision consistency.

Experience

Customer or employee satisfaction, effort, adoption and escalation rate.

Commercial impact

Conversion, retention, win rate, cost avoided or value created.

FUTURE LEADERSHIP

Rethink your role and define success with AI

RETHINK YOUR ROLE AS A LEADER

The role of the leader will change as organisations realise the value of agentic AI. Over time, agents may take a more active role in informing business direction by responding in real time to market conditions and customer needs. Strategies may be set by the week, or even the day, rather than the year.

Leaders will need to adjust to this dynamic: making decisions informed by agents as well as judgement and experience. The human side of leadership will become more important, not less. Leaders will need to set the culture and ambition, rather than focus only on operations.

DEFINING FUTURE SUCCESS WITH AI

Success will look different for organisations and for leaders themselves. How agentic AI is used individually and at company level will be crucial.

Upskill yourself

Build genuine fluency through practical experience, ongoing education and peer learning.

Rethink your role

Move from directing every operational detail to setting ambition, guardrails, culture and accountability.

Visualise the future

Design the organisation, work and capabilities needed to use agents responsibly and effectively.

Invest with intent

Make AI investments that have a clear problem statement, measurable value and accountable ownership.

Now is the time for leaders to adjust: learn, lead and make the investments that deliver true ROI.